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1 Case study "Quality of Product"

Year: Sunday January 1, 1961

1.1 Facts

For many years the ABC Company has manufactured a product which enjoys a high quality rating in the industry and among the public. Competing manufacturers have now introduced a similar product of lower quality at lower cost, and this competition has caused a serious decline in the sales of the product manufactured by the ABC Company. To meet this competition the ABC Company instructs its engineers to redesign its product in order that it may be made available to the market at lower cost. Upon receiving these instructions some of the engineers question whether such an action would be consistent with the Canons of Ethics because a lower quality product under the same brand name would mislead the public into accepting a product of lesser quality in the mistaken belief that it meets the high quality standards with which the product has been associated in the public mind for many years.

- Use to manufacture a High quality product.
- Introduction of similar product from competing manufacturers sold at a lower cost.
- Decline in sales of the product from ABC company.
- ABC company instructs its engineers to redesign the product to lower the cost of the product on the market.
- Engineers question the decision in regards to the Canons of Ethics as this seems misleading to the public into accepting a product of lesser quality as the name of the product remains the same.

1.2 Question

Do the engineers have a proper interest and ethical obligation to protest the company's decision, or to refuse to design a lower quality product?

1.3 Personal opinion on the Dilemma

Keeping the same product name for the lower quality product, could be deciteful to the public if the company fails at being transparent on the drop in quality to the public. So servicing the redesign of the product as a professional Engineer is indirectly contributing at misleading the public. Though the unfavorable reactions will be directed against the company rather than the Engineer.

1.4 Objective argumentation

- Canons rules is to protect and serve the public safety, health and welfare by the application of engineering knowledge and to protect and defend the high standing of the engineer-

ing professions. Meaning if the engineer believes that the redesign into a lower quality product jeopardizes safety or health, Canon 4 clearly indicates their ethical **responsibility/obligation** to advise management.

- Neither the canons nor the Rules, however, deal with business decisions of companies. The canons and rules should be restricted to situations which clearly raise questions of the ethical conduct of individual engineers.

- The lower quality product is exclusively a matter for management determination, based on the company's evaluation of its commercial operations. while the Engineers are respopndible for giving management honest professional advice.

- Neither the Canons nor the Rules, however, deal with business under the Canons or Rules. They may feel that the decision is not a wise one, that it may reflect adversely upon the public acceptance of the Company's product, or even that the public may be misled. These are risks for management evaluation, but there is no reason for the engineers to refrain from offering the company their opinions and comments through normal communication channels within the company. If the public is misled as to the product's quality, the unfavorable reaction will be directed against the company. It would be a disservice to the engineering profession to attempt to extend the Canons and Rules to the point of interference in business decisions of the commercial world.

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2 speaker notes for the presentation

2.1 Introduction

- Good morning everyone and welcome to a short presentation on Engineering Ethics on the case study of **Quality of product**

- During this presentation, I will like to share with you an in depth examination of ethics, professional responsibiliites personal perspectives, and business decision in engineering.

- This is a pretty old case study dating from the 1960s but a really interesting one to me as it shows a possible dilemma in which one can potentially find themseleves in as an Engineer.

2.2 Background and Facts

- So let's quickly have a look into the case study itself.

- Basically there is this company named **ABC**. They have long made high quality products and have earned a strong reputation in the industry
- Competitors have introduced a cheaper, low quality version, and ABC's sales have dropped drastically.
- Management has instructed the Engineering team to produce a new cheaper and low quality design of the same product to be able to compete with the current market.

2.3 Concern

- Engineers questioned if retaining the same brand name for a lesser-quality product violates the canons of Ethics by misleading the public regarding expected product standards.

2.4 The Core Ethical Question

- Do the engineers have a proper interest and ethical obligation to protest the company's decision, or to refuse to design a lower quality product?

2.5 Personal Opinion on the Dilemma

On the company's point of view:

- **Risk of Deceit**: What I mean by that is, Upon release of the product, consumers or the public should me made aware of the drop in quality of the product as a reason for the price drop.
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On the engineer's point of view:

- **indirect involvement**: Right, like in the case where the Engineer is aware of the lack of transparency and still designs the product they are indirectly contributing to misleading the public.

Direction of Fallout: Since no consumer really knows about the Engineers involved in designing the product.

2.6 Ethical Objective Argumentation

Looking at the Dilemma through the lense of Etchical Objective Argumentation,....